Fueling a warming world

By 1904, Arrhenius had become concerned about the dramatic increase of CO_2 due to human actions—primarily through burning fossil fuels, such as coal and oil. He correctly predicted the influence that CO_2 emissions would have on global temperatures, but eventually came to the conclusion that an increase in global temperatures could have a beneficial effect on plant growth and food production.

The burning of fossil fuels has, in fact, increased CO_2 levels more quickly than Arrhenius expected, although the planet has warmed less than he predicted. Scientists understand now that global warming is having damaging effects on people and on the environment, and will continue to do so as long as long as emissions continue to increase.

“The atmosphere may act like the glass of a greenhouse … [raising] the mean temperature of Earth’s surface.”

Nils Ekholm

Swedish meteorologist (1848–1923)
